

Modern Political Theory - Subject: Equality

Prompt - Discuss the role of equality in the political thought of Hobbes and Rousseau. In what respects do they think of humans as being equal or unequal? What is the political relevance of each account of equality?

In the consideration of human beings as equal or unequal, Thomas Hobbes and Jean-Jacques Rousseau establish their own conceptions of equality present in the state of nature. While both these authors are able to identify natural equality within humans, they analyze the products and consequences of this equality in very different ways. Where Hobbes sees equality as the root of humanity's problems, Rousseau takes the opposing side and views equality as the origins of humanity's natural goodness. In this essay, I argue that while Hobbes suppresses natural equality through the creation of a sovereign, Rousseau views equality as an ideal condition that politics must attempt to recreate through a legitimate government and democratic participation.

To begin, Hobbes underlines his entire view on the state of nature, being one of anarchy and dissolution, under the pretense that humans are naturally "so equall, in the faculties of body, and mind" (Leviathan, Hobbes). While one might initially be under the impression that equality is good, Hobbes argues that equality is destructive because "the weakest has enough strength to kill the strongest" (Leviathan, Hobbes), either through trickery or collaboration with others. This idea from Hobbes is essential to understanding that because he views men as so equal, no one can guarantee safety or ever truly feel secure. Equality for Hobbes makes everyone permanently vulnerable and is the precise reason why humans need to allocate their power to a sovereign. Hobbes continues expanding on this state of nature and equality, as he argues that there is a constant and "restlesse desire of Power after power, that ceaseth only in Death" (Leviathan, Hobbes). Equal men in the state of nature will never be content with coexisting and are driven to compete for power. Combined with the insecurity in the idea that anyone has the inherent ability to kill anyone, no one will believe they have accumulated enough power to be safe. To contrast, Rousseau views equality as something to strive for and inequality as source of humanity's downfall. Rousseau believes that in the development of the state of nature, humans land on "the happiest and the most lasting epoch" (Inequality, Rousseau), during his idea of the 3rd stage; nascent society. Rousseau details that in this stage, humans are equal because they are all able to sufficiently meet their needs, with the social bonds of community starting to form through family and the building of huts. However, with the emergence of society,

"everyone began to look at everyone else and to wish to be look at himself" which builds into Rousseau's argument of how vanity and comparison are the first steps "toward inequality and vice" (Inequality, Rousseau). Inequality is not natural for Rousseau but instead outlined in his idea of "amour propre", which is produced by specific developments where humans start to base their self-worth on the views and comparison of others. Rousseau examines society as an antagonist of equality, through "the inequality it engenders that changes and corrupts all our natural inclinations" (Inequality, Rousseau).

Tying the accounts of equality to political relevance, Hobbes views politics and government as a necessary institution to counter the natural equality found in humanity. With the constant insecurity and fear in the state of nature, Hobbes produces the solution of transferring everyone's "power and strength upon one Man" that combines humanity "unto one Will" (Leviathan, Hobbes). As the sovereign has overwhelming power and absolute say, no one has to live in fear of each other any longer. The sovereign is the entity that dictates the laws and rulings, with its only responsibility to be the "safety of the people" (Leviathan, Hobbes). Hobbes's view of the government is one that has no mandate to contribute to the moral elevation or flourishing of its people, but instead its only role being to mitigate the equality between the subjects themselves. Rousseau ties political relevance to equality in a completely opposite manner, as the whole point of Rousseau's government is to restore the original equality in humans. In direct contrast to Hobbes, Rousseau argues "rather than destroying natural equality", his idea of government "substitutes a moral and legitimate equality" for the physical inequalities between men, allowing them to all "become equal by convention and by right" (Social Contract, Rousseau). For Rousseau, the goal of a legitimate government reconstructs equality in a higher form, as natural equality is susceptible to destruction from social hierarchies and divisions of labor. The government is necessary for humans to get along with each other and essential to becoming an equal, self-governing member of a community.

The most important way that Rousseau ties his idea of equality into political relevance is examined in how he legitimizes the government through the "general will". The key to maintaining equality in Rousseau's government is radical democratic participation of every single citizen and this is what creates a legit and equal government. If every person were to follow the general will, then "in a body [they] receive each member as an indivisible part of the whole" (Social Contract, Rousseau). This is a crucial concept to maintain equality in the government, as each individual member becomes part of the sovereign themselves, rather than Hobbes's idea of having an absolute sovereign rule over everyone. Hobbes retains equality in his government by making everyone equally powerless before a single sovereign, whereas Rousseau makes everyone equal

through politics by having everyone simultaneously be the sovereign and the subject. The laws applies to everyone, including the people that made the law, contributing to a civil reconstruction of equality that can function in a society. Furthermore, a legit government helps produce a change in humanity by "substituting justice for instinct" and allowing individuals to "consult his reason before listening to his inclinations" (Social Contract, Rousseau). This government will help prevent inequality because they are no longer looking to improve only themselves, but instead the collective society as a whole. Rousseau's role of a legit government is to help reduce the vanity and comparison in humans, countering amour propre through collective action.

In conclusion, Hobbes and Rousseau both find equality in the state of nature, but offer different forms of government as a solution. Hobbes believes equality puts humans in a state of continuous war, constantly living in insecurity and fear. On the other hand, natural equality for Rousseau is a necessary condition for humans to be free and good, being the goal of what legitimate governments should work to replicate under civil conditions. Rousseau does this through the participation of every citizen and the creation of a sovereign encapsulating everyone, which Hobbes believes humans to be incapable of due to their self-interested nature.

Works Cited

Hobbes, Thomas. *Leviathan* (1996)

Rousseau, Jean-Jacques. *The Social Contract and Other Later Political Writings* (2018)